

NECB 2026 · Reviewer Packet

Everything you need to review abstracts for NECB 2026. Please read both parts before scoring.

- **Part 1 — Abstract Review Rubric** — scoring dimensions, recommendation, calibration.
- **Part 2 — Conflict-of-Interest Policy** — how to flag conflicts, confidentiality.

Reviews due Thu Sep 3, 2026 · 11:59 PM ET.

Score at: <https://forms.gle/pPmsrcyYVuyBfGWR8>

Questions: newenglandcompbio@gmail.com

Reviews are not blinded — author names and affiliations are visible on both the text abstract and the 1-page PDFs, since the optional PDFs almost always embed them. See COI policy in Part 2; score on the science alone (see “What NOT to score” in Part 1).

Part 1 · Abstract Review Rubric

Reviewers: please read this before you start scoring. Adapted from the NeurIPS reviewer guidelines and scaled to a 1-page abstract.

Each submission has up to two pieces:

1. A **250-word text abstract** (from the ISCB submission form) — required.
2. A **1-page print-ready PDF** (single-column, 11 pt serif, US Letter — goes directly into the conference abstract book) — optional.

Important: the 1-page PDF is optional. Submissions **without** a PDF are considered **poster-only** — they cannot be selected for a talk. If a submission has no PDF, cap your Recommendation at **Accept as poster** (or Reject if the science warrants).

Score every dimension for every assigned abstract.

Scoring dimensions

Give each of these four a **1–5 integer score**.

1. Scientific significance

Is the question important? Would the result advance the field?

Score	Meaning
5	Groundbreaking — resolves an open question or opens a new direction.
4	Clearly interesting — advances a known research thread with a meaningful step.
3	Solid but incremental — competently extends prior work.
2	Limited significance — narrow scope, limited applicability.
1	Not significant — repeats existing findings or unclear why it matters.

2. Methodological rigor

Is the approach sound? Are the claims supported by the data / analysis shown?

Score	Meaning
5	Rigorous — appropriate methods, controls, and evaluation. Claims match evidence.
4	Sound with minor caveats — small gaps in evaluation or missing baselines.
3	Mostly sound — a couple of unaddressed concerns, but nothing disqualifying.
2	Serious methodological concerns — key baselines / controls missing, or evaluation questionable.
1	Not sound — claims not supported by the analysis presented.

3. Clarity

Is the abstract well-written and legible without prior context?

Score	Meaning
5	Exemplary — reads cleanly on first pass, figures/tables are self-explanatory.

Score	Meaning
4	Clear with minor rough edges.
3	Understandable with effort — some jargon or structural issues.
2	Hard to follow — main contribution unclear until re-reading.
1	Poorly written or unintelligible.

4. Fit for NECB

Is this computational biology, and appropriate for a regional New England symposium?

Score	Meaning
5	Squarely in scope, would resonate with the audience.
4	In scope, may appeal to a subset of attendees.
3	Adjacent to scope — computational but light on biology, or vice versa.
2	Weak fit — mostly out of scope but has some relevant angle.
1	Out of scope.

Overall recommendation

Pick **one**:

- **Accept as talk** — top ~10–15%. Should be presented from the podium.
- **Accept as poster** — solid contribution worth showing at the meeting. Also the ceiling for submissions with no 1-page PDF.
- **Reject** — out of scope, seriously flawed, or clearly below the poster bar.

Your overall recommendation carries more weight than the individual dimension scores. Use it decisively; don't hide behind "poster" as a default. And remember: **no PDF → maximum recommendation is poster.**

Confidence

Pick **one**:

- **High** — you work in this area and are confident in your judgment.
- **Med** — you can evaluate it competently but it's not your primary field.
- **Low** — outside your expertise; take the score as a rough signal.

Rationale

Two sentences, roughly:

- One line **strength** — what's good.
- One line **concern** — what's weak, missing, or unclear.

Chairs read every rationale. Please write them.

Calibration notes

- **Use the whole 1–5 range.** If everyone clusters at 3–4, chairs can't rank abstracts. A score of 5 should mean "the best of everything I saw." A 1 means "this shouldn't be at the meeting."

- **Trainee submissions are welcome.** Trainee-first is part of NECB's identity. Don't downgrade for early-career polish; do downgrade for weak science.
- **If you're unsure whether something's in scope**, err toward including it and mark **Fit for NECB: 3**. Chairs will make the final call.

What NOT to score

- **Author names / affiliations** — you'll see them (reviews are not blinded), but they should not factor into your scores. Score on the science alone.
 - The formatting of the PDF (11 pt vs 12 pt, etc.) — chairs will handle any formatting issues at the abstract-book stage.
 - Whether the presenting author is a trainee or a PI.
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Part 2 · Conflict-of-Interest Policy

The following relationships between you (reviewer) and any co-author on an abstract constitute a **conflict of interest** and disqualify you from reviewing that abstract.

Conflicts of interest

1. **Same institution** — you and any co-author share a current primary affiliation (department granularity for large institutions like Harvard, MIT, Broad).
2. **Advisor / advisee** — current or former, at any level (PhD, postdoc, senior mentor).
3. **Co-author within the last 3 years** — on a publication, preprint, dataset release, or software release.
4. **Same lab / research group** — currently or within the last 3 years.
5. **Grant or funding** — you are or have been on the same grant / cooperative award within the last 3 years.
6. **Personal or financial relationship** — family, close friendship, or any financial interest in the work.

Upon receiving your assignments, please check for any of the above and email newenglandcompbio@gmail.com as soon as possible so we can reassign.

Confidentiality

Reviews and reviewer identity are **confidential**:

- Do not share abstract content with anyone outside the review committee.
- Do not tell authors that you reviewed their work.
- Do not discuss specific abstracts with other reviewers (calibration questions to chairs are fine).

Rubric adapted from the NeurIPS reviewer guidelines. Policy adapted from NeurIPS + ISCB conference standards. Questions to the organizing committee via newenglandcompbio@gmail.com.